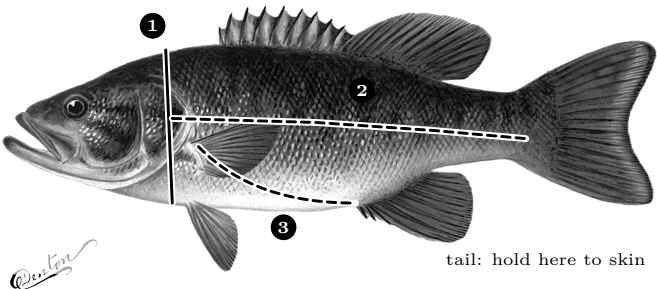


# Cooking Smallmouth Bass

*Micropterus dolomieu* — in the kitchen

Cleaner-tasting than its cousin, because of where it lives



The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

|                     |                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Verdict</b>      | Better eating than largemouth and noticeably cleaner, because smallmouth live over gravel and rock rather than in soft-bottomed weed. ●●●●● |
| <b>Texture</b>      | Firm, white, tight-flaked. The best bass in either lake for the pan.                                                                        |
| <b>Flavour</b>      | Mild with a faint sweetness. A crayfish diet shows in the eating.                                                                           |
| <b>Best size</b>    | 14–17 in. Pine Lake’s gravel bottom produces good ones.                                                                                     |
| <b>Yield</b>        | About 32% as skinless fillet.                                                                                                               |
| <b>Worth saying</b> | Smallmouth are the best sporting fish in these lakes and there are not many big ones. Take a meal, release the rest.                        |

## Filleting

1. **Cut down behind the gill plate** and the pectoral fin, angling slightly toward the head, until the blade meets the backbone. Do not cut through it.
2. **Turn the blade flat** and run it along the top of the backbone to the tail in one long stroke, letting the spine guide the knife. Leave the fillet attached at the tail so it acts as a handle.
3. **Slice the rib cage out** in a shallow arc, taking as little flesh with it as you can.
4. **Skin it:** fillet skin-side down, grip the tail, run the knife between skin and flesh at a slight downward angle while pulling the skin against the blade.
5. Flip the fish and repeat. Rinse in cold water, pat dry, and get it onto ice.

## Bones and what to watch for

|                      |                                                               |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rib cage</b>      | Removed at step 3. Nothing else to deal with.                 |
| <b>Red strip</b>     | Less pronounced than on largemouth, but still worth trimming. |
| <b>Skin</b>          | Comes away cleanly and is not worth eating.                   |
| <b>Check by feel</b> | Run a finger tip-to-tail before cooking.                      |

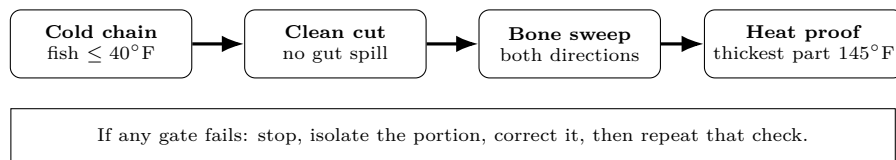
## Cooking it

| Method       | How                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pan-fried    | Flour, salt, pepper, butter. Three minutes a side. Smallmouth is clean enough that heavy seasoning is a waste of it.                                                                               |
| En papillote | Fillet on parchment with lemon, dill, a knob of butter and a splash of white wine. Fold and seal, 400 °F, twelve minutes. Opens at the table.                                                      |
| Over a fire  | A whole gutted smallmouth, scored, stuffed with lemon and herbs, wrapped in foil and buried in coals for twenty minutes. The best thing you can do with one on the shore of the lake it came from. |

## Bottom matters

A fish tastes of where it lives. Smallmouth from Pine Lake's clean gravel are consistently better than largemouth from the same lake's soft weedy bays — same water, different bottom, different flavour. If you want to know how a lake will eat before you cook it, look at what is under the fish. *see the **Reading Water** sheet*

## Prove the meal before serving



| Ask now                             | Pass condition                                                                       | If it fails                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Is the fish still cold?             | Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.                                        | If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”                     |
| Did the knife enter gut or gall?    | No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.                        | Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.   |
| Are the portions actually boneless? | Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.          | Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone. |
| Is the center done?                 | A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F. | Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.                                |

## Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

**Wisconsin safe-eating guidance.** For walleye, pike, bass and catfish: **one serving per month** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per week** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR's Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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